



ATTITUDES OF THE RESIDENTS TOWARDS THE TRADITION OF HOSPITALITY IN THE MOUNTAINOUS REGION OF ADJARA

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RESUME

Tourism is the main driving force in the world in terms of economic empowerment. Sustainable tourism development is related to numerous social, cultural/traditional, environmental, and economic issues. Thus, it may contain unsustainable development without adequate study, identification, and proper tourism management (especially in mountainous regions). Therefore, It should be noted that mountainous regions are the most attractive tourist destinations globally. It is noteworthy that the opportunities and challenges associated with them differ significantly depending on the country/region's natural resources and climate. In addition to the tourism development mentioned above, the local population's and the hospitality-related aspects are significant. We investigated the Attitudes of the Residents towards the tradition of hospitality in the mountainous region of Adjara

Keywords: Tourism, tradition, hospitality, mountainous region, Adjara.

INTRODUCTION

Tourism is one of the main driving forces in the world in terms of economic empowerment. Sustainable tourism development (Ca-

ter, 1993) is related to numerous social, cultural/traditional, environmental, and economic issues (Galuppo et al., 2020). (Środa-Murawska et al., 2021) Indeed, sustainable tourism development provides an opportunity to increase the potential for rational use of existing natural resources without maximizing losses (Naseem, 2021) (Pukowiec-Kurda et al., 2021) (Manzoor et al., 2019) (Galuppo et al., 2020). (Środa-Murawska et al., 2021). Thus, without adequate study, identification, and proper management of critical factors, tourism (especially in mountainous regions) may contain signs/aspects of unsustainable development. Thus, it is essential to thoroughly study tourism-specific economic, social, and cultural/traditional characteristics to develop a sustainable development strategy. This approach enables the short-term and long-term action plan to be adequately developed (VU et al., 2020). Since the sustainable development of tourism involves economic, ecological and socio-cultural aspects, sustainable development is closely linked to the economic viability of the host community in the long run, revenue growth is significantly related to proper tourism management. It should be noted that mountainous regions are the most attractive tourist destinations globally. It is noteworthy that the opportunities and challenges associated with them differ significantly depending on the country / region's natural resources and climate. In particular, the biodiversity traditions/culture of the local population, have a significant impact on tourism development (Bramwell, 2007) (Saarinen, 2006). (Seyedabolghasemi et al., 2022) Thus, the development of the tourism sector, especially mountain tourism, largely depends on the area's specific characteristics, taking into account the features of the environment and cultural heritage (Duglio et al., 2019) (Madanaguli et al., 2021). With its diverse and attractive nature, the mountainous region of Adjara may become new opportunities to develop a sustainable national economy, which will play an essential role in the socio-cultural development of the local population. In general, the development of mountainous region resources is also a challenge. In particular, increasing the number of visitors

can be a challenge in many ways (Christie et al., 2014). Priority is given to the tourism development of the mountain region, using the surrounding resources properly. Therefore, to maintain sustainability, developing a strategic plan for the mountainous region of Adjara requires the use of resources, taking into account the region's specifics as much as possible. Because of the above, it is desirable to consider the problem complex, considering the interdisciplinary approach. The more the issues related to mountain tourism development in Adjara are explored, the more opportunities there will be for the development of the right vision and strategy and the observance of the conditions for the development of sustainable tourism as much as possible, which will be a guarantee for the development of the resources of the rich mountainous zone of Adjara (which is relatively little) without maximum losses.

Georgia is a mountainous country with ancient traditions and culture in the South Caucasus region (Salukvadze & Backhaus, 2020). It should be noted that according to the traditions in Georgia, hospitality is a specific feature of the country, which is also particularly noticeable in the case of the mountainous region of Adjara. In last years, the development of the tourism sector in the Adjara region is gradually expanding. The potential opportunities of the landscape of the mountainous region of Adjara enable the development of tourism in the mountainous region. Especially the ecology, food, traditions/culture of the mountainous region of Adjara create a unique opportunity for tourism development in various directions (ecotourism, wellness tourism, etc.). Thus, in particular, it will help reduce the problem of depopulation in the mountainous region, which will also positively impact the growth of local economic opportunities and, ultimately, the development of sustainable tourism, which will directly affect the sustainable development of the region's economy.

Because of the above, we think that studying the acceptance of the local population in the mountainous region of Adjara will enable us to properly manage tourism, considering the conditions of preservation/protection of the heritage/traditions of the mountainous

region. In particular, we will be able to identify priority issues with a complex approach and strengthen the capacity to address them properly, positively impacting the proper management of tourism in the mountainous region. It should be noted that Keda, Shuakhevi, and Khulo municipalities mainly were settlements in the mountainous region of Adjara. Thus, the role of mountain tourism development in the economy of the Adjara region is essential. Challenges and problems related to mountain tourism at the regional and national levels will help develop the necessary strategies for mountain tourism development. Natural heritage, maximally analyzing the socio-economic aspects of the cultural traditions and local population based on the characteristics of the local people and tourist resources, and especially the thorough study of cultural-ethnographic issues are particularly dangerous. We consider that most of Adjara was declared a border zone, which meant that it was impossible to enter the border zone without a special permit except for local residents. Moreover, mountainous Adjara was not considered a tourist zone for the mentioned period. Thus, the trend of noticeable tourism development in recent years requires a study of the readiness of the local population, especially since the tradition of hospitality provides the best opportunity to attract tourists. In addition, mountain tourism is a unique potential form of tourism globally, which should be planned based on natural resources, especially with maximum local population involvement and/or cooperation with them. (Peira et al., 2021). Especially in recent years, the Kovid-19 pandemic has become particularly relevant in strengthening mountain tourism globally, which may change the approaches to tourism development in mountainous regions, which is reflected in the strategy. In other words, tourism development may become a strategically leading “driver” opportunity for economic empowerment for the mountainous region (Peira et al., 2021), Including in the case of our region may play a crucial role.

As mentioned above, an interdisciplinary approach is essential for developing tourism business, especially sustainable tourism. In

our previous studies, we investigated some aspects of Vocational Education's Short-Term Program in the Tourism Sector, medical tourism resources, innovative technologies within Adjara mountain region (Gogitidze & Nadareishvili, 2021b) (Gogitidze & Nadareishvili, 2021a) (Gogitidze & Nadareishvili, 2020).

Thus, the subject of our research is the study of hospitality in the Adjara mountain region. The study of hospitality as well as the reception of the results, analysis of the obtained results, and their sharing, will enable us to analyze how ready and/or interested a large part of the population is for the development of the tourism business.

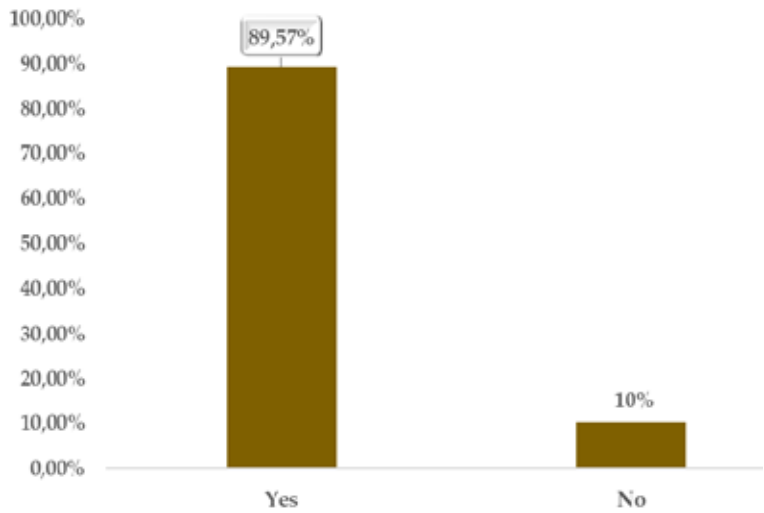
THE STUDY OBJECT AND METHODS:

The study was conducted in the Adjara mountain area, where visitors from different countries are noticed. For tourist visiting, places were selected: the mountain region of Khelvachauri, Keda, Shuakhevi and Khulo mountain area according to the tourist's attention. Notably, the increase in tourism activity was noticed because of to the region's numerous opportunities and potential. During our study, including 2021-2022 years, The quantitative survey based on a questionnaire was used to assess the locals' tourism development aspects of 500 mountain residents (63.15% % female and 26.85% 36.85%) were included **(Picture 1)**.

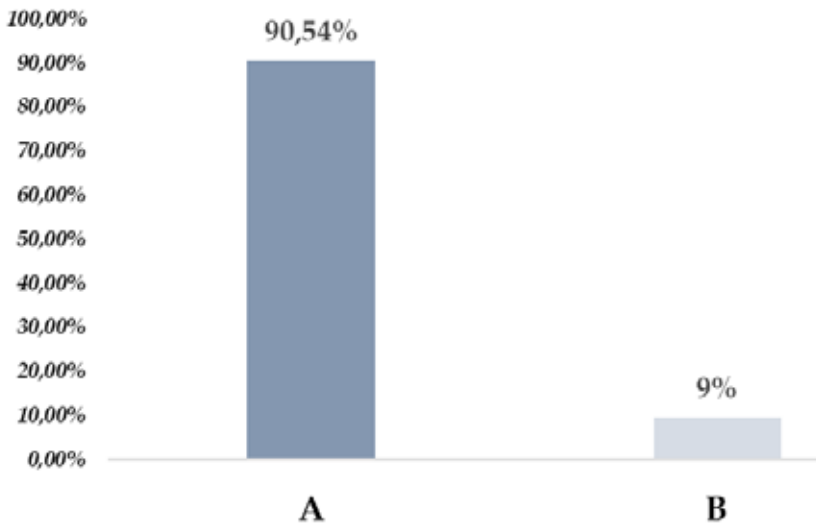
**Picture 1. The percentage of participants according to gender
Female; B. Male**



**Picture 2. Study the existence
of a guest room in a mountainous region**

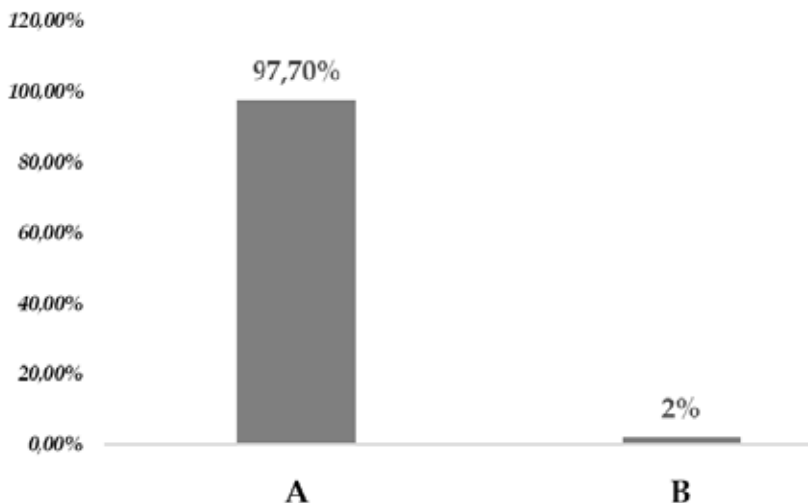


**Picture 3. Survey of residents readiness regarding free overnight
stays of visitors**



Picture 4. Study the willingness to share information related to traditions for tourist

A. Yes B. No



THE RESULTS AND DISCUSSION:

According to a Study of the existence of a guest room in Adjara, a mountainous region, 89.57 % of respondents mentioned having a room for visitors, and only 10% have no room for visitors **(Picture 2)**.

Notably, ~ 9.54 % of respondents (the residents of the Adjara mountain region) are ready to allow free overnight stays for visitors **(Picture 3)**.

According to our study, ~ 97.7% confirmed that they have been sharing the information related to their traditions to visitors in case of wishes **(Picture 4)**.

Hence, increasing attention is required on mountain tourism's development's role in the economics of the Adjara region. In addition, there are numerous issues with mountain tourism at the regional and national level; accordingly, strategies are required more attention during developing mountain for mountain tourism. In par-

ticular, natural heritage, culturally traditional, may have significant effects on sustainable development. Therefore, we have thought mountain tourism is considered a unique potential form of tourism, enhanced by the demand for more sustainable and nature-based solutions. Moreover, tourism strategy is also essential to devise a shared vision and related tools with locals—accordingly, mixed-method approach for involving the local community in a shared development strategy.

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ადგილობრივი მოსახლეობის დამოკიდებულება სტუმარმასპინძლობის ტრადიციასთან დაკავშირებით აჭარის მთიან რეგიონში

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რეზიუმე

ტურიზმი წარმოადგენს მსოფლიოში ერთ-ერთ მთავარ მამოძრავებელ ძალას ეკონომიკური გაძლიერების თვალსაზრისით. ტურიზმის მდგრადი განვითარება დაკავშირებულია მრავალ სოციალურ, კულტურულ/ტრადიციულ, გარემოს დაცვით და ეკონომიკურ საკითხებთან. ამრიგად, აღნიშნული ფაქტორების ადეკვატური შესწავლის, პრობლემის იდენტიფიკაციისა და სათანადო მართვის გარეშე, ტურიზმი (განსაკუთრებით მთიან რეგიონებში) შეიძლება შეიცავდეს არამდგრადი განვითარების ნიშნებს. უნდა აღინიშნოს, რომ მთიანი რეგიონები ყველაზე მიმზიდველი ტურისტული მიმართულებებია მსოფლიოში. აღსანიშნავია, რომ მათთან დაკავშირებული შესაძლებლობები და გამოწვევები მნიშვნელოვნად განსხვავდება ქვეყნის/რეგიონის ბუნებრივი რესურსების და კლიმატის მიხედვით. გარდა ზემოთ აღნიშნულისა, ტურიზმის განვითარებაზე მნიშვნელოვან გავლენას ახდენს ადგილობრივი მოსახლეობის ტრადიციები და სტუმარმასპინძლობასთან დაკავშირებული ასპექტები. წარმოდგენილ კვლევაში ჩვენს მიერ შესწავლილია ადგილობრივი მოსახლეობის დამოკიდებულება სტუმარმასპინძლობისადმი აჭარის მთიან რეგიონში.

საკვანძო სიტყვები: ტურიზმი, ტრადიცია, სტუმარ-მასპინძლობა, მაღალმთიანი რეგიონი, აჭარა.